

2024

BROKEN DOLLS

CLAUDIO GOBBER ART

www.claudiogobber.art

Preface

“Broken Dolls” originates from a fragment of the world I choose to observe and distill. I take broken dolls, objects discarded, overlooked, or forgotten and transform them into sculptural works through the use of cement, plaster, cotton gauze, vinyl glue, and acrylic pigments. These dolls are not just materials; they stand as direct metaphors for many women who, after dedicating years to raising their children, often find themselves set aside in a similar way, unseen, undervalued, or no longer considered “useful” in the professional world and beyond.

By transforming these figures, fixing, covering, hardening, and elevating them, I reveal the strength and resilience of those women. The new sculptural bodies that emerge echo their own journey: a return to visibility, dignity, and purpose, not despite their fractures but through them.

“Broken Dolls” distills a fragment of our time, reminding us that what has been set aside can rise again with renewed power and presence. This is my commitment as an artist: to give form to the silent stories within this fragment of our society, turning fragility into solidity, weight, and meaning.

Introduction

Broken Dolls explores the condition of being set aside, forgotten, or overlooked, an experience shared by many objects and many women. The broken doll becomes a symbol: something once valued, later pushed to the margins, yet still holding the potential for transformation.

In an artistic context, Broken Dolls represents the act of taking what has been discarded and giving it new substance. Old and broken dolls, cement, plaster, cotton gauze, vinyl glue, and acrylic pigments form new bodies, stratified, heavy, enduring. The process reveals not just a change of material but a shift of meaning: fragility becomes form, silence becomes presence, abandonment becomes narrative.

"Art is not what you see, but what you make others see."
Edgar Degas

In a social context, Broken Dolls mirrors the journey of many women who, after devoting years to others, children, families, systems, find themselves overlooked, undervalued, or treated as if their worth had expired. Their struggles are not confined to the professional world and not only; they permeate identity, visibility, and self-perception. The sculptures echo these stories: rigid, layered, transformed, yet always carrying the traces of what they once were.

"The most courageous act is still to think for yourself. Aloud."
Coco Chanel

In a personal context, Broken Dolls speaks to resilience, how fractures, interruptions, and expectations shape a life. The work invites the viewer to confront the quiet violence of being dismissed and the power of rising again with a new structure, a new skin, a new weight.

Emotional awareness is central: understanding the scars, the pauses, the buried strength. Alongside this, qualities such as endurance, reinvention, and the refusal to dissolve into silence form the core of the project. They allow these transformed figures and the women they symbolize to reclaim visibility and meaning.

In today's world, recognizing and restoring what has been set aside is essential, not only as an artistic gesture but as a social responsibility. **Broken Dolls** reminds us that what appears broken is often only waiting for a new form, a new purpose, and a new dignity.

Conceptual Explanation

The twelve figures in *Broken Dolls* are not random characters; they form a deliberate narrative arc that reflects twelve facets of women's resilience, identity, and transformation. Each name holds a symbolic presence, and each description captures a specific emotional or existential condition that many women experience when navigating a world that often sets them aside.

Together, they compose a choral structure, twelve voices, twelve gestures, twelve states of being, that reveal the complexity of rebirth after invisibility, interruption, or silence.

- **Anna** opens the cycle as a suspended moment, grace held in mid-air, inviting the viewer to see time differently.
- **Eva** anchors the beginning with introspection, the inner gaze that precedes change.
- **Sophia** embodies the weight of unspoken stories, a reminder of how deeply silence can shape a life.
- **Clara** preserves the memory of discarded dreams and the quiet insistence of hope.
- **Lucia** represents shattered expectations and the slow reorientation toward a new horizon.
- **Isabel** rises from stone, illustrating how identity can be reborn from solidity and struggle.
- **Nina**, an inverted bloom, flips the natural order and shows that resilience often grows from unlikely positions.
- **Maya** remains hidden in plain sight, revealing the tension between visibility and invisibility.
- **Lila** contorts upward from rigid cement, capturing the awkward effort of finding space in an unyielding world.
- **Elena** demonstrates liberation as a layered process—never immediate, always unfolding part by part.
- **Amara** carries the timeless struggle of women across generations, physically embedded in the material that both restrains and defines her.
- **Zara** concludes the cycle as a rising figure of emerging strength, the embodiment of reclaimed power.

Conceptual Explanation

When viewed together, these twelve figures trace a journey from silence to emergence:

- from introspection (Eva)
- to silence and weight (Sophia)
- to discarded dreams (Clara)
- to shattered expectations (Lucia)
- to rebirth (Isabel)
- to unexpected resilience (Nina)
- to hidden strength (Maya)
- to contorted struggle (Lila)
- to slow liberation (Elena)
- to timeless obstacles (Amara)
- to newly claimed power (Zara)
- to the suspended beauty of becoming (Anna)

The twelve sculptures therefore form a cycle of resilience, twelve chapters of the same story, expressed through different postures, materials, and symbolic tensions.

They stand as a collective portrait of women who have been set aside, overlooked, or fragmented, yet continue to rise, redefine themselves, and reclaim space through strength that is both quiet and immense.

This is the essence of Broken Dolls:

Not a single narrative, but a constellation of transformations, each sculpture illuminating one facet of the journey from being broken to becoming unbreakable.



CLARA



LUCIA



ELENA



EVA



AMARA



ANNA



SOFIA



ISABEL



NINA



LILA



ZARA



MAYA

Closing Letter

To the Quiet Strength Within You

You, standing here and looking at these figures, can feel the weight of starting again as if the world were asking you to step back onto a stage you once left, whether to bring life into the world or simply because life itself paused you for a while. I am speaking to you directly: those cracks you feel are not your ending; they are the marks of your story. You are not alone. Every doll you see here is a testament that fractures can become beauty, that your strength lives in the scars you carry.

And isn't this something we all share, the quiet struggle to rebuild ourselves when life has reshaped us?

Beginning again may feel unnatural, but within these works lies the evidence that you can find new confidence.

This is not the end of your freedom; it is the beginning of a new chapter, one that stands in quiet defiance of a world that now celebrates only the brightest, the loudest, the "best of the best." In an age shaped by social media and endless comparisons, too many are pushed to feel rejected, insignificant, or somehow not enough.

But you are not here to compete with a filtered world. You are here to reclaim the space that belongs to you.

Your cracks are not disqualifications; they are the proof that you have lived, endured, and are still capable of rising in your own way, at your own pace.

Biography



Born in Trentino in 1979, Claudio Gobber grew up in the magnificent valleys of Primiero and Vanoi. Inspired by artists like Riccardo Schweizer, Simone Turra, and Giuliano Orsingher, Claudio's mission is to create time capsules, works that challenge, move, and enlighten. His art explores humanity's deepest questions and themes such as dignity, adaptation, love, and legacy. He recognises himself as a sculptor, painter, photographer, and designer with a passion for new technologies.

After a period of studying in Milan, where he obtained a bachelor's degree and a master's degree in Advertising, he moved to London, where he lived for 10 years. During his time in London he was immersed in the world of photography, practicing the teachings of his photographer grandfather. This modern adventure was accompanied by regular sessions in the mountain studio where he continued to paint and sculpt.

More recently he has been working in Trentino, where alongside numerous acrylic works, a recent inclination towards creating clay sculptures has emerged. His art is strongly influenced by the digital works emerging from the Crypto movement, such as NFTs by international emerging artists, with a particular interest in the use of Generative Art software.

His artistic journey has encompassed both traditional techniques and digital experimentation, fueled by curiosity. He is constantly exploring various art forms. His aim is to push the boundaries of his creativity, producing aesthetically pleasing and conceptually stimulating works. His hope is to produce creations that evoke emotions, inspire reflection, and offer a unique perspective on the world around us.

His art has been exhibited in various national and international shows, and his work has been well received by diverse audiences. He continues to nurture his passion for art and seek new ways to express his creativity.

Description of the Sculptures:

The Broken Dolls series consists of twelve sculptural figures created from discarded plastic dolls transformed through layered, mixed-media techniques. Each piece is individually reconstructed using cement, plaster (gesso), vinyl glue, cotton gauze, and acrylic pigments. The process involves coating, embedding, and hardening the original forms to create new bodies that carry the weight and texture of resilience.

The surfaces are intentionally irregular, revealing fractures, scars, and stratified layers that mirror the conceptual essence of the project. Every sculpture maintains the original posture of the doll while gaining mass, structure, and permanence through the material transformation.

The works vary in size, with average dimensions ranging from 25 × 15 cm to 35 × 35 cm, depending on the pose and the extent of the cement and plaster layering. Together, these twelve sculptures form a unified narrative of rebirth, strength, and silent endurance.

Valuations details:

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